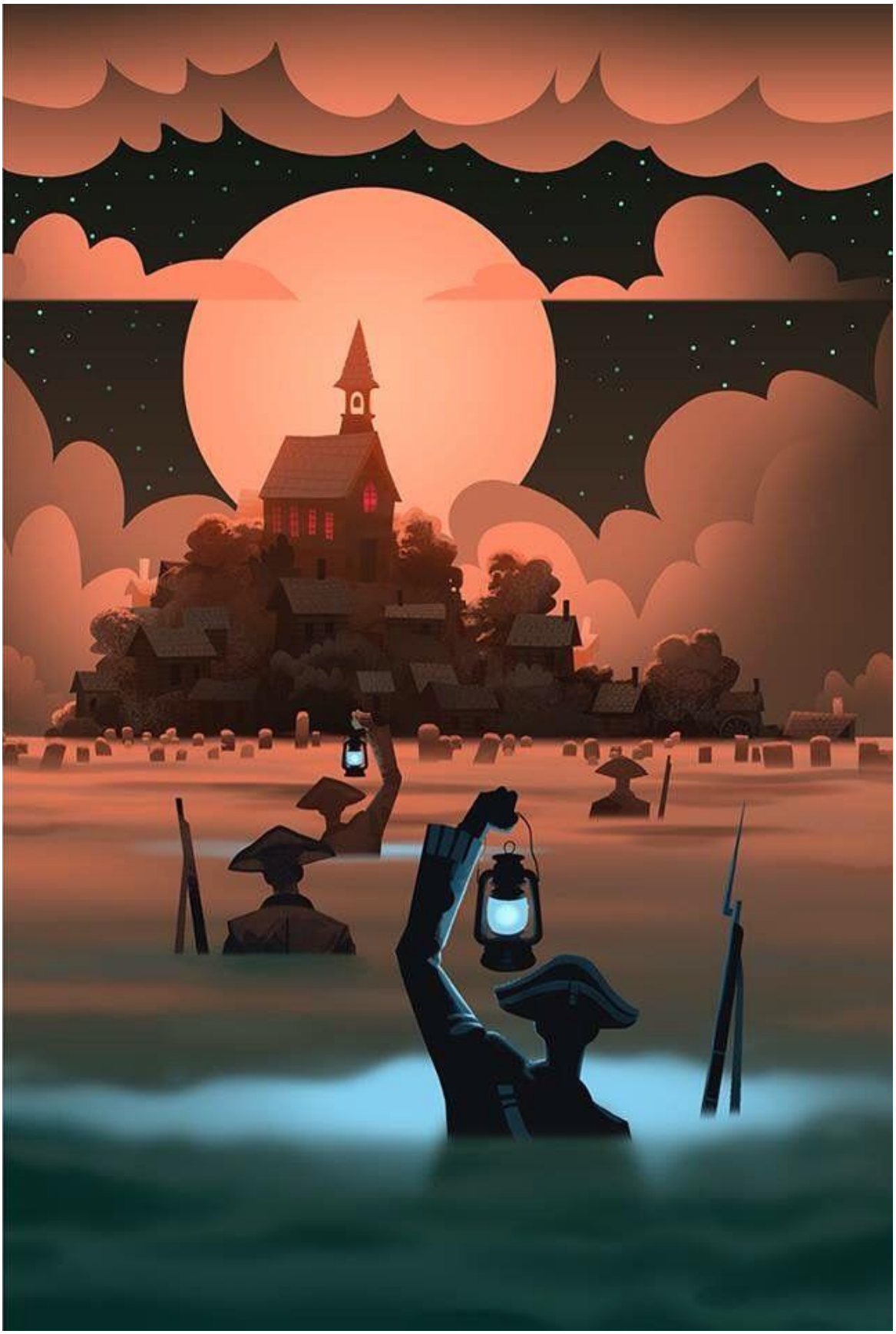


# THE LANTERNMEN OF BLACKWOOD

BY

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The blood moon hung bloated and sickly in the sky, casting a bruised, orange glow over the world. It was a color that promised no comfort, only the rot of a forgotten age. Below, the mist clung to the ground like a shroud, a living, breathing thing that smelled of cold mud and the unquiet dead. We were in Blackwood, a name whispered in taverns with a shudder and a sign of the cross. A name that was now our only path.

“Stay close to the light,” Elias rasped, his voice a low, gravelly sound that was swallowed by the fog the moment it left his lips. He was the oldest of us, a man whose face was a road map of every sin and storm he had weathered. His lantern, a gnarled thing of brass and glass, pulsed with a strange, otherworldly blue light. We had bought them in a forgotten port for a king’s ransom, artifacts said to be crafted by a reclusive coven of witches. They were our only hope, the only known ward against the things that stirred in the Blackwood marshes.

Beside me, Jebediah, a youth no older than eighteen, shivered despite the humid air. He clutched his own lantern, the blue light making his face a ghostly mask. We were smugglers, but our last run had gone awry, our ship wrecked on a jagged shoal. We had fled inland with what little cargo we could salvage, only to find our path blocked

by the marsh, a graveyard of lost souls and shattered dreams. The only way to the town of Haven, our supposed sanctuary, was straight through it.

We waded into the brackish water, the cold seeping through our boots and chilling us to the bone. The cemetery was not on solid ground, but a floating, waterlogged expanse of tilted tombstones and splintered wooden crosses. The fog was a near-physical presence, pressing in on us, a silent legion of the damned.

Then, we saw them.

They were everywhere, scattered in the mist like forgotten stones. Figures half-submerged in the water, their backs to us, their forms rigid and still. They wore tattered coats and tricorn hats, their outlines indistinct against the oppressive gloom. Some of them carried lanterns, identical to our own, but their light was extinguished, their glass panes dark and empty. They were the silent audience of our trespass, a ghostly congregation of the lost.

“What… what are they?” Jebediah whispered, his voice trembling.

“The forgotten,” Elias answered, his gaze fixed on the glowing church atop the distant hill. “Those who tried to

pass and failed. Keep walking. Don’t look at them. Just look at the light.”

We pushed on, our footsteps a quiet, sloshing rhythm in the still water. The air grew colder, and a sudden silence fell over us, a silence that was more terrifying than any sound. It was the silence of a place that should have been alive with the hum of insects and the croak of frogs, but was instead utterly, profoundly dead.

Suddenly, a low, guttural moan sliced through the stillness, seemingly from the very fog itself. Jebediah yelped, stumbling backward. His foot caught on something beneath the water, and he fell. His lantern, a precious beacon, slipped from his grasp and went dark as it hit the water with a soft splash.

“No!” Silas yelled, lunging forward.

Before he could reach it, a hand, dark and skeletal, rose from the water and clamped onto Jebediah’s wrist. His eyes went wide with terror, and a choked scream ripped from his throat.

“Pull him!” Elias commanded, his lantern’s blue glow illuminating the horror. The hand was not flesh and bone, but a thing of mud and weed, its fingers unnaturally long and thin.

We grabbed Jebediah, pulling with all our might. He was surprisingly heavy, as if the water itself was holding him down. We managed to yank him free just as the hand's grip tightened. The sound it made was not a human gurgle, but the sickening squelch of mud and rotted fabric. Jebediah scrambled to his feet, his breathing coming in frantic, ragged gasps. He was unharmed, but his face was a portrait of pure, unadulterated terror.

We had to press on without his lantern, the three of us huddled around the two remaining sources of blue light, a fragile island of safety in a sea of darkness. The incident had changed something. The silence was now a predatory thing, and we could feel the eyes of the silent figures in the fog upon us.

As we neared the hill, the figures became more numerous, more distinct. I saw a man with a shattered spyglass hanging from his belt, a woman with a faded shawl clutched to her chest, a young boy with a wooden toy ship. Their faces were turned towards the church, their empty eye sockets fixed on its faint, red light. I realized with a shudder that they were not merely standing in the water; they were marching, a slow, eternal procession towards the hill.

I looked at Elias's face in the blue light, and for the first time, I saw a flicker of something in his eyes—not fear, but a weary, somber resignation.

"Elias," I said, my voice barely a whisper. "What is this place, truly?"

He didn't answer. Instead, his gaze was fixed on a figure that had emerged from the mist directly in front of us. It was a man in a captain's coat, a familiar scar marring his cheek. He was holding an unlit lantern.

Jebediah whimpered, his eyes wide. "The captain… he was lost at sea. How… how is he here?"

Elias said nothing, his eyes locked on the captain. The man in the coat raised his hand, and a ghostly blue light flared to life in his unlit lantern. A beckoning gesture.

"He's calling us," Jebediah sobbed, and without a word, he began to step forward.

"No, Jeb!" I yelled, but it was too late. He was like a marionette on a string, drawn to the flickering blue light. As he took his first step out of our combined light, the fog surged forward, and the silent figures around us seemed to shift, their forms turning to face him. He let out a shriek that was abruptly cut short as he sank beneath the water,

the ripples the only sign of his passing. The water where he had stood was now still again.

I stared in horror, my breath caught in my throat. I looked at Elias, and in that moment, the final, terrifying truth of Blackwood came to me. Elias was not a guide. He was a survivor. He had been here before.

“They never let you leave,” I said, the realization cold and sharp as a knife.

He finally looked at me, his eyes now filled with a deep, ancient sorrow. “The Lanternmen of Blackwood,” he said, his voice a ghost’s whisper. “The lanterns don’t ward them off, Silas. They call to them. They mark the path. The town… the church… it’s not a sanctuary. It’s the final destination. You wade to the church to join the procession forever.”

The ghostly captain beckoned again, his form shimmering in the sickly moonlight. I looked at the silent figures, and I saw now that they were not just a collection of the dead. They were a grim, horrifying mirror. The pirate with the spyglass was my future. The young boy was Jebediah. And the old man, his eyes hollow and empty, staring into the abyss, was Elias.

Elias had been here before, had seen this same procession. He had likely watched his crew vanish into the fog, just as I had watched Jebediah. And he had turned back, condemned to wander the Blackwood for all eternity, until the time came to lead new souls to their final, eternal post. He was a sentry of the damned, and his lantern was a cursed beacon.

He held his lantern out to me, his face a mask of weary despair. “It’s your turn, Silas. The path is open.”

I looked at the path to the church, bathed in the moon’s sickly glow, and I looked back at the foggy expanse from which we came. Both were paths to death. One was a slow, agonizing slide into the void, the other a life of unending terror, of wandering forever in the cold water, waiting for the next ship to wreck, for the next soul to claim.

I knew my choice. I turned from Elias and the beckoning path, and with the last of my strength, I plunged back into the dark and the chilling silence. I would not be a Lanternman. I would not join the procession. I would fight the darkness until my last breath, even if it meant I would forever be a fugitive in the eternal night.